Ratan—as he is too polite to interrupt anxious conversationalists. I was overseeing his visit and managing his programme when, as the distinguished invitee of President Pranab Mukherjee, he was staying at the Dwarka Suite of Rashtrapati Bhavan that has pampered world leaders like General Secretary Leonid Brezhnev, President Dwight Eisenhower, Queen Elizabeth II and Prince Akihito who later became the Emperor of Japan.

I was thrilled when the President also gifted Ratan two of my books on Rashtrapati Bhavan that I had written as his additional secretary; he usually presented these to visiting heads of states when they called upon him.

The conversations with Ratan during his visit were freewheeling. He spoke about his first dream job in 1962 as an architect in a bespoke firm in Los Angeles, where he found his first love, an American girl whom he wanted to settle down with. We found common ground when he veered to defence matters, an area close to my heart; he had helped design some buildings to house test-jigs for Atlas rockets.

He had evidently been enamoured by what he was doing in the US and led an exciting personal life. And then, suddenly, as if he were recounting a wrenching decision that he took, he said that if it were not for his grandmother and his commitment to the group, he would have stayed back, working and spending his life in the US, which he calls his second home.

That he could utter these words despite the fact that it was the Tata Group that made him a celebrity, was an admission to how much he missed the US. I promptly asked him, ‘Do the people in India know this?’ He replied, ‘Most don’t.’

It then struck me that this is an inspirational story—how Ratan gave up an assured and personally preferred life in the US to one in India that he believed he was duty-bound to pursue, though no one had assured him of any future in the Tata Group. For nearly three decades after he returned to India, his future in the group looked uncertain, but he continued placing his duty above the self for the values he had imbibed from his greatest influencer, his grandmother: values that the group represented and that his grandmother had said needed to be unfailingly embraced, a responsibility he felt had now become his.

Then on a visit to Mumbai with my son, George Thomas, who is in the Indian Foreign Service, in early 2018, I took the chance to call Ratan and tell him that we were in town and for my son, it would be an honour to see